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Localizing global ESG frameworks and sustainable development goals in multinational breweries in Tanzania

Almas Fortunatus Mazigo^{1,2*}

*Correspondence:

Almas Fortunatus Mazigo
mazigo.almas@udsm.ac.tz

¹Dar es Salaam University College of Education (DUCE), Dar es Salaam, Tanzania

²Centre for Applied Ethics, Stellenbosch University, Stellenbosch, South Africa

Abstract

This study examines how two multinational breweries operating in Tanzania—Tanzania Breweries Limited (TBL) and Serengeti Breweries Limited (SBL)—integrate environmental, social, and governance (ESG) strategies and align their operations with the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). Using a qualitative comparative case study approach and underpinned by stakeholder and institutional theory, the study analyzes sustainability and ESG reports from 2018 to 2024. The results of the analysis show that TBL, a subsidiary of AB InBev, achieved a 15% reduction in water use between 2022 and 2023, attained a water-use efficiency of 2.7 hectoliters per hectoliter (hl/hl), and 89.8% of its packaging was returnable or composed of recycled materials. In contrast, SBL, owned by Diageo, invested 380 million Tanzanian shillings (TSh) in the construction of the Kwamizi Dam in the Tanga Region, providing 108,800 cubic meters of clean water to 2000 beneficiaries, and empowered over 100 persons with disabilities—half of them women—through agricultural and business training. TBL demonstrates leadership in environmental innovation and circular resource management, while SBL exhibits a strong social-inclusion orientation, advancing gender equity and community livelihoods. Both firms show clear alignment with SDGs 6 (clean water and sanitation), 12 (responsible consumption and production), and 13 (climate action), although their strategic priorities reflect the influence of their parent corporations and local contextual adaptations. This study contributes to ESG scholarship in the African manufacturing sector by revealing how global sustainability frameworks are localized in emerging markets. The findings have practical and social implications, illustrating how corporate sustainability initiatives can foster inclusive development, empower marginalized groups, and strengthen the role of business in advancing national development goals.

Keywords Corporate sustainability, ESG integration, Sustainable development goals (SDGs), Multinational corporations in Africa, Tanzania beverage industry



1 Introduction

Over the past two decades, sustainability has shifted from a peripheral corporate concern to a core strategic priority, particularly as businesses grapple with the complex interplay of environmental, social, and governance (ESG) challenges. The rise of global frameworks, such as the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), has accelerated this transformation, urging the private sector to align profit motives with societal and ecological well-being [22, 57]. In this context, corporate sustainability—defined as the integration of ESG considerations into organizational decision-making and operations—has gained traction not only in developed economies, but also in emerging markets, including those in sub-Saharan Africa.

In Africa, sustainable development remains a pressing concern, shaped by historical inequalities, environmental vulnerabilities and institutional capacity constraints [1, 24]. While governments remain primary custodians of national development, the private sector is increasingly recognized as a powerful force for achieving the SDGs through innovation, investment, and inclusive business models [31, 41]. However, African corporate sustainability research largely centers on extractive industries—mining, oil, and gas—where social and environmental issues are most visible [9, 29, 30]. By comparison, manufacturing and consumer goods sectors attract far less academic attention despite their substantial socio-economic influence [7, 36].

Tanzania presents a unique case for examining private sector sustainability efforts, as it is undergoing rapid industrialization while addressing challenges such as water scarcity, youth unemployment, gender inequality, and waste management [58]. The country's beer industry is dominated by two major players—Tanzania Breweries Limited (TBL) and Serengeti Breweries Limited (SBL)—whose parent companies, AB InBev and Diageo, respectively, are global leaders in ESG reporting and sustainability. Both companies have committed to various sustainability targets, including water stewardship, renewable energy, circular packaging, and inclusive value chains [5, 16].

Despite the publication of annual sustainability reports by both firms, and increased public engagement on ESG issues, there remains a notable gap in peer-reviewed academic analysis comparing how these companies implement sustainability practices within Tanzania's specific socio-economic and regulatory context. Most existing studies tend to focus broadly on corporate social responsibility (CSR) in Africa [42, 60], with limited emphasis on ESG performance metrics, SDG alignment, and local impact assessment within the beverage industry. Furthermore, the influence of multinational ownership on local sustainability approaches in African subsidiaries is underexplored, especially in terms of how global ESG mandates are adapted or localized [34, 37].

This paper addresses this gap by conducting a comparative case study of TBL and SBL, focusing on the historical evolution of their sustainability journeys, ESG implementation strategies, and alignment with the SDGs. The paper explores the following research questions: (i) How have TBL and SBL integrated ESG principles into their operations and governance frameworks? (ii) Which SDGs are most prominently aligned with their sustainability strategies? and (iii) What are the similarities and differences in their ESG approaches and outcomes? By answering these questions, the paper advances scholarly understanding of how sustainability is implemented, contested and institutionalized in emerging market firms.

2 Literature review

Sustainability in the private sector has evolved from a peripheral corporate concern to a central strategic imperative, especially in the light of global development frameworks such as the SDGs. The integration of ESG factors into corporate strategy is now recognized not only as a risk management tool, but also as a driver of long-term value creation [21]. The academic discourse increasingly emphasizes that corporate sustainability requires more than compliance, it entails a fundamental shift in how companies define their purpose and measure their performance.

2.1 Theoretical foundations of corporate sustainability

The literature identifies several theoretical lenses through which corporate sustainability can be understood. Stakeholder theory [25] emphasizes the moral and strategic imperative of balancing the needs of diverse stakeholders beyond shareholders. This framework provides a foundation for embedding sustainability across business operations. In his work on the triple bottom line approach, Elkington [23] asserts that financial success must be evaluated alongside environmental and social outcomes. Meanwhile, legitimacy theory offers an institutional perspective, suggesting that businesses engage in sustainability practices to maintain societal approval and align with evolving norms and expectations [51]. These theories converge in their implication that sustainability is not optional—it is integral to organizational survival and success in dynamic socio-political environments.

Institutional theory, particularly the concept of isomorphism, further explains how firms mimic the sustainability practices of industry leaders and global actors, often as a response to normative pressures, regulatory expectations, or the pursuit of legitimacy in global markets [17]. This is particularly relevant for firms in developing countries, where formal regulations may be underdeveloped, but global affiliations and stakeholder scrutiny compel the adoption of international standards [10].

2.2 ESG practices in emerging and frontier markets

ESG adoption in emerging markets, including sub-Saharan Africa, is characterized by both opportunities and constraints. On the one hand, these markets face pressing development challenges—such as poverty, inequality, and environmental degradation—that align closely with the objectives of ESG frameworks. On the other hand, limited regulatory enforcement, resource scarcity, and institutional voids pose significant barriers to implementation. Nevertheless, multinational enterprises (MNEs) have increasingly become vectors of ESG diffusion by acting as conduits for global best practices (Eweje, 2006).

Firms linked to international networks—through ownership, supply chains or capital markets—are often subject to normative expectations around sustainability, which influence their disclosure practices and operational decisions. However, this process is mediated by the local context, including cultural norms and socio-political dynamics. Amaeshi et al. [1] argue that ESG adoption in Africa is often reinterpreted to reflect domestic institutional realities, resulting in hybrid models that combine global standards with localized approaches.

Moreover, ESG considerations are increasingly shaping capital flows. Investors now assess environmental and social performance as part of financial risk evaluation, which

incentivizes firms in Africa to strengthen their disclosure of and performance in ESG criteria. However, concerns remain regarding ‘greenwashing’ and the performative use of ESG for reputational gain rather than transformative change. This underscores the need for stronger accountability mechanisms and third-party verification to ensure ESG becomes a driver of meaningful corporate reform.

2.3 Corporate contributions to the SDGs

The adoption of the SDGs in 2015 reframed the role of the private sector in development. No longer seen merely as a source of philanthropy or job creation, businesses are now expected to contribute proactively to goals such as clean water (SDG 6), gender equality (SDG 5), decent work (SDG 8), and climate action (SDG 13). Scheyvens et al. [49] argue that the SDGs provide a strategic framework for aligning business objectives with societal needs, enabling firms to identify areas of shared value.

Corporate alignment with SDGs is most effective when embedded in governance, innovation and value chain management. However, studies have shown that many firms struggle with operationalizing SDGs, particularly in measuring their impact. Pineda-Escobar [43] notes the lack of standardized metrics, and the challenge of aligning short-term business priorities with long-term development goals. Furthermore, reporting often lacks rigor and consistency, limiting the potential for benchmarking or comparative evaluation.

Inclusive stakeholder engagement is crucial for the effective implementation of the SDGs. Community consultation, co-creation of initiatives, and participatory monitoring not only enhance legitimacy, but also ensure that interventions are contextually relevant and sustainable. This is particularly vital in African settings, where distrust of corporate actors may be rooted in histories of exploitation and marginalization. Without meaningful engagement, even well-intentioned SDG initiatives may fail to achieve their intended outcomes.

2.4 African perspectives on corporate sustainability

African scholarship has increasingly challenged the dominance of Western sustainability models, advocating for a more grounded and context-sensitive understanding of corporate responsibility on the continent. Lisk [40] and Visser [61] emphasize that sustainability in Africa often emerges from practical imperatives—such as maintaining a license to operate, securing supply chains, and addressing pressing socio-environmental risks—rather than from normative commitments.

There is a discernible shift toward strategic sustainability in Africa, especially among firms with international linkages or operations in sectors subject to high stakeholder scrutiny. However, this progress is uneven. Extractive industries have attracted considerable academic attention due to their visible environmental impacts and history of social conflict, while other industries, such as food and beverages, remain relatively under-researched despite their significant ecological footprints and social reach.

The beverage industry is relevant due to its high water and energy use, dependence on agriculture, and ties to informal retail. Yet little research explores how African beverage firms engage with ESG or SDGs. This represents a missed opportunity to understand how mid-sized firms, particularly in consumer goods, contribute to—or detract from—sustainable development in complex socio-economic contexts.

While there is a growing body of literature on ESG and SDG integration, sector-specific, comparative research in African contexts remains sparse. Most studies focus on either large-scale mining or agriculture, overlooking the strategic sustainability efforts of firms in the manufacturing and consumer sectors. Furthermore, few studies assess how different corporate ownership models, particularly the influence of multinational parent companies, affect the localization of sustainability practices. The current study fills these gaps by offering a comparative analysis of TBL and SBL, which operate under the global sustainability frameworks of AB InBev and Diageo, respectively.

3 Methodology

This study employs a qualitative, comparative case study approach to explore the ESG practices and SDG alignment of Tanzania Breweries Limited (TBL) and Serengeti Breweries Limited (SBL). A case study approach is particularly appropriate for the in-depth examination of contemporary phenomena within real-life contexts, especially where the boundaries between the phenomenon and its context are not clearly evident [62]. This design enables a rich, contextual, and nuanced understanding of organizational practices, making it well suited for examining corporate sustainability strategies in emerging markets.

The comparative case study method allows for a holistic understanding of how two firms with different corporate structures, ownership, and market positioning implement sustainability strategies in Tanzania's evolving socio-economic landscape. TBL, a subsidiary of AB InBev, and SBL, owned by Diageo through East African Breweries Limited (EABL), represent diverse yet influential players in the Tanzanian private sector. Comparing these firms offers insights into how multinational corporate governance, local operational realities, and industry-specific challenges intersect to shape sustainability initiatives.

Data collection was based primarily on secondary sources, including published sustainability and ESG reports, annual reports, official corporate press releases, CSR disclosures, financial statements, industry analyses, policy documents, and third-party assessments. This approach aligns with established documentary analysis methods in sustainability research, where publicly available data provide valuable insights into corporate strategies and outcomes [8].

To enhance data reliability and credibility, reports were drawn from company disclosures between 2018 and 2024, capturing longitudinal developments in sustainability practices. Specifically, the analysis drew from TBL's ESG and Sustainability Reports (2023 to 2024) and EABL's group-level Sustainability Reports (2023 and 2024), which include detailed metrics for SBL. Both companies' reports are prepared in accordance with the Global Reporting Initiative (GRI) Standards, ensuring standardized, comparable, and transparent reporting across environmental, social, and governance dimensions. In addition, SBL's disclosures align with the Nairobi Securities Exchange (NSE) ESG Disclosure Guidelines (2021), while TBL's reporting is guided by AB InBev's global ESG framework, itself structured around the UN Global Compact Principles and the Sustainability Accounting Standards Board (SASB) benchmarks. These frameworks provide consistent metrics for evaluating corporate performance in areas such as carbon emissions, water use, packaging circularity, inclusion, and governance transparency.

Triangulation was applied to strengthen the trustworthiness of the findings by cross-verifying information across multiple years, reports, and independent sources. Where possible, data trends were validated through consistency checks among different reports (e.g., annual reports, ESG disclosures, and third-party reviews). Attention was also given to each company's alignment with key SDGs—particularly SDG 6 (clean water and sanitation), SDG 12 (responsible consumption and production), and SDG 13 (climate action)—identified based on the thematic focus of their sustainability activities and alignment with global development priorities. Although the study applied triangulation to enhance reliability, it relied primarily on corporate disclosures and third-party assessments. Future research could strengthen validity by integrating perspectives from community beneficiaries, non-governmental organizations, and local authorities to capture a more holistic view of sustainability performance and stakeholder experiences.

Stakeholder theory and institutional theory provided the guiding theoretical frameworks. Stakeholder theory emphasizes the importance of balancing the interests of diverse internal and external actors (Freemond, 1984), while institutional theory explains how organizational behaviors are shaped by external pressures such as global norms, regulatory frameworks, and societal expectations [17]. These theoretical lenses enable the interpretation of how TBL and SBL respond to both corporate mandates and contextual sustainability pressures, adapting global ESG agendas to local Tanzanian realities.

Finally, the findings from both case studies were synthesized and critically compared to identify patterns, divergences, and implications for corporate sustainability in emerging markets. This comparative analysis contributes to a deeper understanding of how multinational corporate actors in developing economies localize global sustainability frameworks, while simultaneously addressing national development priorities and community-level challenges.

4 Historical overview of the firms

Corporate sustainability initiatives are often shaped by a firm's history, ownership structure and market evolution. The distinct historical trajectories of TBL and SBL provide context for understanding their respective approaches to ESG practices and alignment with the SDGs.

4.1 Tanzania Breweries limited (TBL)

TBL traces its roots to the early colonial era, established in 1932 as Tanganyika Breweries Limited. In 1935, it was acquired by Kenya Breweries, and by 1936 it had become a part of the East African Breweries Ltd (EABL) consortium. Following Tanzania's post-independence nationalization policies, TBL was nationalized in 1976, which led to a period of stagnation and inefficiency due to limited technological advancement and bureaucratic constraints. The economic liberalization of the 1990s prompted the privatization of the company in 1993, with South African Breweries (SABMiller) acquiring a controlling stake [52].

AB InBev's 2016 acquisition of TBL marked a strategic shift, embedding global sustainability frameworks in local operations. The company has since become a key arm of AB InBev's operations in East Africa, integrating global sustainability frameworks, such as the 2025 Sustainability Goals, into its local strategy [2]. TBL is listed on the Dar es

Salaam Stock Exchange (DSE), and holds a dominant market share of approximately 80% in Tanzania's beer industry [59].

As a legacy company with extensive production and distribution networks, TBL has leveraged its scale to implement sustainability practices focused on water stewardship, smart agriculture, circular packaging and renewable energy [53]. Its corporate history of transformation—from nationalization to global integration—has positioned it as both an economic and sustainability leader in Tanzania.

4.2 Serengeti Breweries limited (SBL)

SBL was founded in 1988 as Associated Breweries, a local initiative aimed at increasing competition in a market that has long been dominated by TBL. Its flagship product, Serengeti Premium Lager, was introduced in 1996, establishing SBL as a significant player in the premium beer segment [18]. In 2002, the company was rebranded as Serengeti Breweries Limited. In 2010, it underwent a major structural change when East African Breweries Ltd (EABL), a Diageo subsidiary, acquired a 51% controlling stake [12].

The acquisition brought SBL under the umbrella of Diageo's global operations, allowing it access to international expertise, supply chain integration and ESG frameworks aligned with Diageo's "Society 2030: Spirit of Progress" strategy [14]. Since then, SBL has expanded its production capacity across three breweries in Dar es Salaam, Mwanza and Moshi, growing its market share to approximately 15% [19].

Unlike TBL, SBL is not listed on the Dar es Salaam Stock Exchange (DSE), but reports its performance through EABL, which is publicly traded on the Nairobi Securities Exchange. SBL's relatively recent establishment and foreign majority ownership have influenced a more focused and strategically targeted approach to sustainability. Key ESG initiatives include water access projects, responsible drinking campaigns, and inclusion programs targeting women and people with disabilities [19].

SBL's journey illustrates how foreign direct investment can catalyze the adoption of international sustainability standards in a local context. Its evolution from a domestic competitor to a Diageo-affiliated entity has redefined its operational philosophy, embedding sustainability in its core business model.

5 Environmental, social and governance (ESG) analysis

This section critically examines the ESG strategies of TBL and SBL, using both empirical data and theoretical frameworks from contemporary sustainability literature. ESG frameworks have become increasingly central in assessing corporate performance beyond traditional financial metrics, capturing a firm's environmental stewardship, societal contributions, and internal governance mechanisms [21]. As Kotsantonis et al. [38] argue, ESG integration reflects an organization's resilience and long-term value-creation strategy.

5.1 Environmental initiatives

TBL and SBL have adopted proactive environmental strategies as part of their corporate sustainability mandates, aligned respectively with AB InBev's 2025 Global Sustainability Goals and Diageo's "Society 2030: Spirit of Progress" framework. These strategies focus on water stewardship, energy efficiency, renewable energy transition,

waste management, and circular packaging, thereby operationalizing commitments to SDGs 6, 7, 12, and 13.

TBL has achieved notable progress in resource efficiency and circularity. In 2023, the company reduced total water use by 15% year-on-year [54]. In 2024, TBL sustained a water-use efficiency of 2.7 hl per hl of beer produced [55]. Its packaging portfolio reached 89.8% returnable or recycled content by 2024, positioning it among the regional leaders in circular packaging. TBL also replaced diesel-powered forklifts with low-emission LPG alternatives, eliminated PET plastic bottles for beverages such as *Grand Malt*, and expanded the use of aluminum cans to improve recyclability. These efforts align closely with SDG 12 (responsible consumption and production), and demonstrate tangible progress toward a circular economy. Moreover, the company is targeting 100% renewable electricity and a 25% reduction in carbon emissions across its value chain by 2025, supported by the incremental adoption of solar power and energy-efficient brewing technologies.

In parallel, SBL has advanced a complementary set of environmental priorities emphasizing community-based water stewardship and the adoption of renewable energy. In 2023, SBL invested TSh 380 million in partnership with WaterAid and the local government to construct the Kwamizi Dam in Handeni District, Tanga Region. The dam, with a capacity of 108,800 m³, now supplies clean water to approximately 2000 beneficiaries, strengthening local resilience to drought and water insecurity [19]. This initiative directly supports SDG 6 (clean water and sanitation) and reflects SBL's community-centered approach to environmental sustainability. At the operational level, SBL continues to optimize energy use through solar and biomass integration, the introduction of LPG-powered forklifts, and ongoing waste-reduction programs that have moved the company toward zero waste-to-landfill status. These interventions collectively contribute to SDGs 7 (affordable and clean energy) and 13 (climate action).

In sum, both breweries demonstrate a strong and evolving commitment to environmental sustainability, although with different emphases: TBL prioritizes technological efficiency and circular-production innovation, whereas SBL foregrounds community-level resource stewardship and renewable-energy adaptation. Together, their efforts illustrate how multinational subsidiaries can translate global corporate sustainability mandates into context-specific environmental action within Tanzania's brewing industry.

5.2 Social initiatives

Social sustainability refers to a company's capacity to generate positive societal outcomes through equitable employment, inclusive growth, community investment, and education [11]. Both TBL and SBL have implemented programs aimed at uplifting underserved populations and improving livelihoods, aligning their efforts with SDGs 3, 5, 8, and 10.

TBL, aligned with AB InBev's global ESG framework, continues to advance social impact through its retailer development program (RDP), launched in 2023. The initiative trains small and micro-enterprises in inventory management, financial literacy, and marketing skills, aiming to economically empower over 28,000 local retailers across Tanzania. Complementing this, TBL sustains over 90% local sourcing by volume, strengthening domestic value chains and supporting more than a thousand smallholder barley and sorghum farmers. In partnership with the International Finance Corporation (IFC) and CRDB Bank, the company provides pre-financing seed capital and agronomic

training, promoting food security and rural livelihoods [33, 53]. Collectively, these interventions advance SDG 8 (decent work and economic growth) and SDG 10 (reduced inequalities) by empowering local entrepreneurs and enhancing market access.

SBL's social initiatives, under Diageo's "Society 2030: Spirit of Progress" strategy, prioritize inclusion, education, and empowerment. In 2023, SBL partnered with the Ministry of Agriculture and the Foundation for Disability Hope to train 100 persons with disabilities—50% of whom were women—in agribusiness and entrepreneurship [19]. At the group level, EABL (2024) reports that 40% of its 60,000 smallholder farmers are women, and between 700 and 1,200 persons with disabilities participate across its value chain, reinforcing inclusive agricultural development. SBL also runs the Kilimo Viwanda scholarship program, which has supported over 200 students from farming communities, with a strong emphasis on gender equity and disability inclusion [19, 20]. These initiatives contribute directly to SDG 5 (gender equality) and SDG 10 (reduced inequalities) by broadening participation in productive sectors.

In the area of public health, SBL implements awareness campaigns on responsible alcohol consumption through Diageo's DRINKiQ and "Wrong Side of the Road" platforms, reaching more than 8,000 students and 5,000 drivers with behavior-change messaging [15]. TBL [53] complements this approach through collaborative campaigns with Tanzanian traffic authorities, including a road-safety mobile app and responsible-drinking messages embedded across marketing channels. These efforts align with SDG 3 (good health and well-being) by reducing alcohol-related harm and fostering a culture of moderation.

In summary, both breweries have institutionalized social sustainability as a core business priority. TBL demonstrates leadership in economic empowerment and local value-chain development, while SBL excels in social inclusion, education, and public-health advocacy. Together, their initiatives showcase how corporate actors can translate global ESG commitments into inclusive, community-centered development outcomes within Tanzania's brewing industry.

While both companies disclose the scope of their community and inclusion programs, data on outcome-level impacts such as income growth, employment creation, or educational attainment remain limited. Future studies should incorporate independent impact assessments to measure how these initiatives translate into tangible social and economic benefits for participating stakeholders.

5.3 Governance and ethical practices

Corporate governance provides the ethical infrastructure through which companies ensure compliance, transparency, and accountability in pursuit of sustainable business practices [63]. It encompasses adherence to regulatory frameworks, ethical conduct, stakeholder engagement, and transparent reporting. Both TBL and SBL have embedded governance systems that integrate international ESG standards with national regulatory obligations, demonstrating alignment with SDG 16 (peace, justice and strong institutions) and SDG 17 (partnerships for the goals).

TBL, as a publicly listed company on the Dar es Salaam Stock Exchange (DSE), adheres to Tanzania's corporate-governance code and AB InBev's Global Code of Business Conduct. Its governance framework incorporates the UN Guiding Principles on Business and Human Rights, ensuring that operations respect community water rights,

labor protections, and environmental standards [4]. TBL's ESG strategy is guided by AB InBev's ESG Reporting Standards and the Global Reporting Initiative (GRI) framework, which provide transparent disclosure on sustainability indicators such as carbon emissions, water efficiency, packaging circularity, and occupational safety. The company also engages in regular compliance audits and publishes independently verified annual reports, underscoring a commitment to ethical operations and stakeholder accountability.

Although SBL is not publicly listed, it is held to comparably rigorous governance standards through its parent corporations, Diageo plc and East African Breweries Limited (EABL). Its sustainability disclosures comply with GRI 2021 [27] Standards and the Nairobi Securities Exchange (NSE) ESG Disclosure Guidelines (2021), reflecting a structured and transparent approach to ESG monitoring. Under Diageo's "Society 2030: Spirit of Progress" strategy, SBL tracks metrics on waste management, water stewardship, inclusion, and ethical conduct. The company has also received commendation from Tanzania's National Environment Management Council (NEMC) for environmental compliance, particularly in achieving zero waste to landfill and maintaining strong safety and governance practices.

Stakeholder engagement constitutes a core dimension of governance for both breweries. TBL partners with government agencies, including the Ministry of Agriculture and environmental NGOs such as WWF and the Safe Water Network, to co-design and implement sustainability programs addressing water management, agricultural productivity, and biodiversity protection. SBL collaborates with civil-society organizations such as Sightsavers and the Foundation for Disability Hope (FDH) to promote inclusion and community empowerment. These partnerships exemplify best practices in stakeholder-inclusive governance, reinforcing transparency and collective accountability.

In summary, the governance architectures of TBL and SBL go beyond symbolic compliance; they are structurally embedded in their business models and reporting systems. TBL's approach reflects strong alignment with international corporate-governance benchmarks and investor-transparency requirements, while SBL demonstrates robust internal accountability and ethical oversight within the Diageo–EABL network. Together, these breweries illustrate how Tanzanian enterprises, guided by global corporate frameworks, can operationalize ESG principles to advance environmental protection, social equity, and ethical business conduct in emerging markets.

5.4 Comparative summary of ESG performance

The comparative evidence presented above shows that, while TBL and SBL share overarching sustainability commitments, their priorities and implementation approaches diverge in important ways. TBL demonstrates leadership in environmental performance and operational efficiency, whereas SBL distinguishes itself through social inclusion, community investment, and inclusive value-chain development. The following tables synthesize the firms' performance data, milestones, and sustainability alignment with the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

Table 1 confirms that both firms demonstrate measurable environmental and social performance aligned with multiple SDGs. TBL's quantitative reductions in water and carbon intensity indicate the strong operational integration of ESG targets, while SBL's

Table 1 Comparative ESG performance of TBL and SBL (2018–2024).

Source: Compiled from TBL 2023 and 2024 annual reports and EABL 2023 and 2024 sustainability reports

Dimension/ SDG alignment	TBL	SBL	Key SDGs
Environmental Stewardship	15% reduction in water use (2022–2023) Water efficiency 2.7 hl/hl (2024) 89.8% returnable or recycled packaging Target 100% renewable electricity by 2025	Constructed Kwamizi Dam (TSh 380 million; 108,800 m ³ ; 2,000 beneficiaries) Solar and biomass energy integration Zero waste to landfill (2023)	SDG 6 (clean water) SDG 7 (clean energy) SDG 12 (responsible consumption) SDG 13 (climate action)
Social inclusion & community impact	Retailer development program (28,000 retailers trained) 90% local sourcing Partnerships with IFC and CRDB Bank for smallholder finance	100 persons with disabilities trained (50% women); 40% of 60,000 farmers trained are women [20] 200 + Kilimo Viwanda scholarships Responsible-drinking campaigns (8000 students, 5000 drivers)	SDG 3 (good health) SDG 5 (gender equality) SDG 8 (decent work) SDG 10 (reduced inequalities)
Governance & partnerships	Listed on DSE AB InBev code of conduct and UN guiding principles on human rights Partnerships with WWF and safe water network	Global Reporting Initiative ([GRI], (2021 and NSE ESG Guidelines (2021) Diageo's <i>Society 2030</i> framework Commended by NEMC for compliance Partnerships with Sightsavers and FDH	SDG 16 (institutions) SDG 17 (partnerships)

Table 2 Timeline of sustainability milestones for TBL and SBL (2018–2024).

Source: Compiled from company ESG and sustainability reports (2018–2024)

Year	TBL milestones	SBL milestones
2018–2019	Initiated circular-packaging pilot with returnable glass bottles	Expanded responsible-drinking education program in secondary schools
2020	Formed local barley- and sorghum-sourcing partnerships	Launched <i>Society 2030: Spirit of Progress</i> strategy under Diageo
2021	Adopted AB InBev ESG framework and renewable-energy targets	Achieved zero waste to landfill across all breweries
2022	Expanded watershed restoration projects in Dar es Salaam	Introduced solar and biomass energy in production facilities
2023	Published first comprehensive ESG report (Aug 2023); achieved a 15% reduction in water use	Constructed Kwamizi Dam (TSh 380 million; 108,800 m ³ ; 2,000 beneficiaries); trained 100 people with disabilities (50% women)
2024	Achieved 2.7 hl/hl water efficiency and 89.8% returnable packaging; targeting 100% renewable electricity by 2025	Extended Kilimo Viwanda scholarships (200 + students); expanded EABL inclusion program (40% of which are female farmers)

inclusive social investments illustrate human-centered sustainability outcomes that address gender and equality dimensions.

Table 2 illustrates the temporal progression of sustainability integration within the two breweries. TBL's steady operational improvements correspond with AB InBev's global targets, while SBL's milestones track Diageo's *Society 2030* commitments. The timeline demonstrates how global frameworks are localized over time through concrete, incremental actions.

Table 3 maps the specific linkages between each brewery's ESG actions and the SDGs. TBL's strategy concentrates on resource efficiency and environmental stewardship, aligning strongly with SDGs 6, 12, and 13, whereas SBL's social programs correspond more

Table 3 ESG–SDG Alignment of TBL and SBL (2018–2024).

Source: Compiled from company sustainability and ESG reports (2018–2024)

ESG pillar	TBL – key initiatives (2018–2024)	Aligned SDGs	SBL – key initiatives (2018–2024)	Aligned SDGs
Environmental	15% reduction in water use (2022–2023) Water efficiency 2.7 hl/hl (2024) 89.8% returnable packaging Target 100% renewable electricity by 2025	6 – Clean water and sanitation 7 – affordable and clean energy 12 – responsible consumption and production 13 – climate action	Kwamizi Dam (TSh 380 million; 108,800 m ³ , 2,000 beneficiaries) Solar and biomass energy integration Zero waste to landfill (2023)	6 – clean water and sanitation 7 – affordable and clean energy 12 – responsible consumption and production 13 – climate action
Social	Retailer development program (28,000 retailers) smallholder finance partnerships with IFC & CRDB bank	3 – good health and well-being 5 – gender equality 8 – decent work and economic growth 10 – reduced inequalities	200 + Kilimo Viwanda scholarships 40% female farmers 100 persons with disabilities trained Responsible-drinking campaigns (8,000 students, 5,000 drivers)	3 – good health and well-being 5 – gender equality 8 – decent work and economic growth 10 – reduced inequalities
Governance	Listed on DSE AB InBev code of business conduct Partnerships with WWF & safe water network	16 – peace, justice and strong institutions 17 – partnerships for the goals	GRI 2021 and NSE ESG Guidelines (2021) Partnerships with Sightsavers, FDH, and NEMC	16 – peace, justice and strong institutions 17 – partnerships for the goals

directly with SDGs 5, 8, and 10. Both companies converge on governance-related goals (SDGs 16 and 17), illustrating shared commitments to accountability and partnership.

Taken together, Tables 1, 2, and 3 provide an integrated picture of how TBL and SBL have translated global sustainability frameworks into measurable and locally relevant practices. TBL's trajectory highlights operational efficiency, packaging circularity, and environmental innovation, while SBL's record emphasizes inclusion, education, and social resilience. The comparative evidence reinforces that sustainability in Tanzania's brewing sector is multifaceted—driven simultaneously by global corporate mandates and by context-specific community needs. These complementary pathways demonstrate how multinational subsidiaries can act as powerful agents of sustainable development within emerging-market contexts.

6 Alignment with the sustainable development goals (SDGs)

The adoption of the SDGs by companies globally reflects a growing commitment to sustainable business practices that extend beyond compliance and profit-making. According to the United Nations Global Compact [UNGC, 2015, p. 3] [56], the SDGs provide “a universal, integrated and transformative vision for a better world,” calling on the private sector to align strategies and operations with social and environmental priorities. As nations strive to achieve the 2030 Agenda, the role of businesses—particularly in developing economies—has become increasingly vital. Companies that embed SDG targets into their core operations not only contribute to global goals, but also enhance competitiveness through risk mitigation, innovation, and stakeholder trust [45].

TBL and SBL have actively embedded the SDGs within their sustainability frameworks, guided by their parent companies—AB InBev and Diageo—respectively. These affiliations have provided structured, measurable approaches to SDG alignment, ensuring localized impact through global best practices. The following section examines how

each company aligns its ESG strategies with specific SDGs, and the measurable outcomes of these efforts.

6.1 Tanzania breweries limited (TBL)

TBL's sustainability initiatives align prominently with several SDGs. Key among these is SDG 6 (clean water and sanitation). TBL's partnership with WWF in the Dar es Salaam Water Security Project demonstrates a focused effort to protect urban watersheds, such as the Msimbazi and Ruvu rivers, which are crucial to the city's water supply. AB InBev's 2025 Sustainability Goals reinforce this commitment by aiming for "100% of communities in high-stress areas to have measurably improved water availability" (Anheuser-Busch [3], p. 5). In addition to watershed restoration, TBL monitors its water usage ratio and implements process innovations to reduce water consumption per hectoliter of beer produced.

TBL also supports SDG 13 (climate action) through targeted decarbonization strategies. These include replacing diesel forklifts with LPG-powered alternatives, investing in energy efficiency, and exploring renewable energy sources. Its 2022 ESG report highlights a multi-site initiative to transition all breweries to renewable electricity by 2025, in line with AB InBev's global climate goals [53]. Such efforts contribute to national commitments under the Paris Agreement, and reflect the urgency of business-led climate mitigation.

In line with SDG 12 (responsible consumption and production), TBL has adopted circular packaging practices—94% of its packaging is returnable, and 33% of glass bottles are made from recycled material [53]. The company has eliminated single-use PET bottles for certain non-alcoholic products, further reducing plastic waste. These actions promote a circular economy and reduce the environmental impact of packaging waste.

TBL's Smart Agriculture Initiative targets SDG 2 (zero hunger) by supporting small-holder farmers through agronomic training, financial services and climate-resilient practices. In collaboration with the CRDB Foundation, TBL has introduced pre-financing schemes to boost barley production, thereby addressing food security and ensuring income stability. This initiative also aligns with SDG 8 (decent work and economic growth) by enhancing agricultural productivity and creating rural employment opportunities.

TBL's Retailer Development Program promotes entrepreneurship and financial literacy among over 28,000 retailers, contributing further to SDG 8. The structured training enhances local business resilience, enabling small-scale vendors to thrive in competitive markets. Furthermore, the appointment of the company's first female managing director in 2024 underscores its commitment to SDG 5 (gender equality), highlighting a dedication to inclusive leadership and workplace diversity.

6.2 Serengeti Breweries limited (SBL)

SBL's sustainability strategy, guided by Diageo's "Society 2030: Spirit of Progress," aligns with a broad range of SDGs. Through its "Water for Life" initiative, SBL has constructed over 20 water-access projects, including a solar-powered treatment plant in Manyara Region that serves more than 14,000 people—advancing SDG 6 (clean water and sanitation) [18]. These projects not only improve health and sanitation, but also reduce the

time spent—predominantly by women and children—in fetching water, thereby supporting SDG 5 and SDG 3.

On SDG 13 (climate action) and SDG 7 (affordable and clean energy), SBL has achieved a 50% reduction in energy consumption and is committed to transitioning all its facilities to renewable energy sources. LPG forklifts have replaced diesel across all sites, and solar installations are ongoing [19]. These interventions demonstrate a clear understanding of environmental responsibility and align with the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change's ([IPCC], 2022) [32] call for rapid decarbonization in industry.

SBL's circular economy efforts, which include achieving zero waste in landfills and making nearly 100% of plastics recyclable or compostable, align closely with SDG 12. Such achievements are particularly notable when national waste management infrastructure remains limited.

Regarding SDG 5 (gender equality) and SDG 10 (reduced inequalities), SBL has prioritized inclusive procurement and workforce practices. Nearly 40% of its smallholder farmers are women or persons with disabilities, and its scholarship program for agribusiness studies has supported over 200 youth—50% of whom are female [19]. This focus reflects Diageo's global inclusion strategy, which emphasizes supplier diversity and equitable access to economic opportunities.

SBL also contributes to SDG 3 (good health and well-being) through its DRINKiQ and "Wrong Side of the Road" campaigns, which have reached over 15,000 people with education on responsible drinking and reducing harm from alcohol [18]. These programs support WHO recommendations on reducing harmful alcohol consumption, and are delivered in partnership with health ministries and NGOs.

Furthermore, SBL's community investment extends to SDG 4 (quality education). The company's Kilimo Viwanda scholarship program fosters human capital development by enabling rural youth to pursue tertiary education in agricultural sciences and business. Such efforts build long-term capacity in Tanzania's agricultural and food systems, and align with national education priorities.

While both breweries demonstrate robust SDG engagement, their approaches reflect the strategic priorities of their parent companies. TBL emphasizes environmental resource management, sustainable agriculture, and economic empowerment through retail and farmer support programs. In contrast, SBL leads in social inclusion, waste management, and health-oriented education. These distinctions suggest complementary roles in Tanzania's sustainable development ecosystem, with TBL acting as an environmental and supply chain innovator, and SBL as a community-centric, inclusive growth advocate.

This diversity of focus enriches the broader landscape of corporate sustainability in Tanzania. As Sachs et al. [46] argue, localized SDG implementation is most effective when diverse actors contribute based on their strengths and institutional capacities. Both companies contribute to Tanzania's Development Vision 2025 and National Five-Year Development Plan III, which emphasize industrial growth, social equity, and environmental sustainability.

In line with Elkington's [23] "Triple Bottom Line" framework, both companies illustrate how economic, environmental, and social objectives can be harmonized. Their practices affirm that corporate sustainability is no longer optional, but a critical determinant of long-term success [44]. Integrating the SDGs into core business strategy—not

just CSR programs—illustrates a shift towards transformational rather than transactional sustainability.

TBL and SBL exemplify the potential for private sector leadership to achieve the SDGs in sub-Saharan Africa. Their efforts provide valuable lessons for other industries seeking to embed sustainability in business models and demonstrate that, with commitment, even traditional sectors like brewing can become engines of sustainable development.

7 Comparative analysis

This section presents a comparative analysis of TBL and SBL concerning their sustainability strategies, ESG practices, and alignment with the SDGs. While both companies operate in Tanzania's alcoholic beverage sector and are influenced by their global parent companies—AB InBev for TBL and Diageo for SBL—their sustainability journeys demonstrate different emphases and implementation pathways.

7.1 Strategic framing and global influence

TBL and SBL derive their sustainability frameworks primarily from their multinational parent companies. TBL follows AB InBev's 2025 Sustainability Goals, which focus on five key areas: smart agriculture, water stewardship, circular packaging, climate action, and responsible drinking (Anheuser-Busch [4]). In contrast, SBL is guided by Diageo's "Society 2030: Spirit of Progress" agenda, which integrates ESG goals across three strategic pillars: positive drinking, inclusion and diversity, and grain-to-glass sustainability [13].

These frameworks shape each company's priorities. As Porter and Kramer [44] assert, integrating CSR into core operations fosters shared value by simultaneously enhancing competitiveness, and advancing social conditions. TBL's strategy leans more heavily on environmental performance and efficient resource use, while SBL places substantial emphasis on inclusion, community impact, and equitable growth.

7.2 Environmental sustainability

TBL's environmental achievements are focused largely on water and packaging. Its partnership with WWF in the Dar es Salaam Water Security Project exemplifies a multi-stakeholder approach to watershed conservation, aligning with SDG 6 (clean water and sanitation). TBL also boasts a 94% returnable packaging rate and has switched to aluminum cans for Grand Malt, eliminating PET bottles [53]. In addition, TBL is progressing toward its goal of sourcing 100% of its electricity from renewable sources.

By contrast, SBL has realized zero waste to landfill across all its sites, a milestone that underlines its commitment to SDG 12 (responsible consumption and production). Furthermore, the company achieved a 50% reduction in energy and water use over a five-year period, and has begun integrating solar and biomass energy solutions [19].

As Schaltegger and Burritt [47] note, environmental performance should not be seen as a cost, but as a value-adding dimension of modern business strategy. Both companies illustrate this, but SBL's waste and energy achievements present a slightly more advanced stage of environmental innovation.

7.3 Social responsibility and inclusion

Social sustainability reveals sharper contrasts. SBL has made significant strides in empowering marginalized groups. By 2024, 40% of its contract farmers were women or persons with disabilities—a direct contribution to SDGs 5 (gender equality) and 10 (reduced inequality) [SBL, 2024, p. 14] [50]. Its scholarship programs and partnerships with NGOs such as Sightsavers showcase a robust community-centered model.

TBL's social impact has grown recently, with initiatives like the Retailer Development Program and the appointment of its first female managing director. While these efforts are meaningful, they are relatively new and less comprehensive than SBL's embedded inclusion strategies.

Elkington [23] emphasizes the need for integrating equity and empowerment into corporate sustainability under the triple bottom-line framework. SBL's targeted initiatives in education, supplier diversity, and inclusion suggest the deeper institutionalization of social goals.

7.4 Governance and accountability

Governance practices in both companies reflect high standards, although they are shaped by different accountability mechanisms. As a publicly traded company on the Dar es Salaam Stock Exchange (DSE), TBL adheres to strict reporting obligations, including standalone ESG reporting since 2022. Its public profile has led to recognition at national SDG awards, particularly for SDGs 6 and 13 [53].

SBL benefits from Diageo's comprehensive governance framework, and is subject to regular internal audits and reporting via EABL. Although not publicly listed, it maintains high transparency standards, and hosts stakeholder engagement forums with NGOs, regulatory bodies, and communities.

According to Sachs et al. [46], corporate contribution to the SDGs is maximized when governance systems are inclusive, transparent, and aligned with long-term development objectives. Both TBL and SBL demonstrate these qualities, although TBL has greater exposure to investor-driven accountability, SBL exhibits more direct engagement with social stakeholders.

8 Discussion

The sustainability practices of TBL and SBL provide rich case studies for examining how private-sector enterprises in sub-Saharan Africa integrate ESG principles into their strategic and operational frameworks. The comparative findings reveal not only the influence of their global parent corporations—AB InBev for TBL and Diageo for SBL—but also the critical role of local adaptation in translating global sustainability frameworks into contextually effective practices.

The growing literature underscores the indispensable role of the private sector in achieving the SDGs. Sachs et al. [45] (2019, p. 806) argue that business enterprises are pivotal in addressing global development challenges, particularly in low- and middle-income countries where public resources are constrained. In the Tanzanian context, both breweries contribute directly to national development priorities such as water security, renewable energy transition, job creation, and inclusive economic growth.

Multinational corporations (MNCs) often act as conduits for best practices, knowledge transfer, and governance reform. Kaplinsky and Morris [35] highlight how MNCs

can diffuse global standards into emerging markets. This dynamic is evident in TBL's adherence to AB InBev's 2025 Global Sustainability Goals, and SBL's alignment with Diageo's "Society 2030: Spirit of Progress" framework. These structured corporate blueprints have enabled both firms to pursue measurable sustainability targets—such as TBL's 15% reduction in water use between 2022 and 2023, its water efficiency of 2.7 hl/hl, and ITS 89.8% percent returnable packaging rate, alongside SBL's TSh 380 million investment in the Kwamizi Dam (108,800 m³ capacity), which has benefited 2000 residents, and its training of 100 persons with disabilities (50% of whom are women).

However, as Visser [61] cautions, replicating Western CSR models without contextual grounding risks limited impact. Both breweries exemplify contextual adaptation by embedding sustainability within Tanzania's socio-environmental realities. TBL's watershed restoration projects with WWF in the Ruvu and Msimbazi basins, along with SBL's community-based water and renewable-energy initiatives, demonstrate locally responsive strategies addressing water scarcity and resource resilience—key components of SDG 6 (clean water and sanitation).

The firms further embody a shift toward inclusive business models that directly address socio-economic inequality. SBL's empowerment of women and persons with disabilities through inclusive farming programs, and TBL's retailer development program, which has trained over 28,000 entrepreneurs, exemplify the political role of business described by Scherer and Palazzo [48]. These initiatives transcend traditional philanthropy, advancing SDG 5 (gender equality), SDG 8 (decent work and economic growth), and SDG 10 (reduced inequalities) through structural inclusion and economic participation.

Both companies have operationalized the triple-bottom-line paradigm proposed by Elkington [23], balancing profitability, social equity, and environmental stewardship. TBL's circular-packaging leadership and SBL's zero-waste-to-landfill achievement illustrate practical expressions of the circular-economy model advocated by Geissdoerfer et al. [26], emphasizing restorative and regenerative production systems. These accomplishments demonstrate how sustainability can be embedded in value-chain processes, rather than treated as a peripheral CSR activity.

Nevertheless, persistent challenges concern transparency, verification, and long-term impact assessment. KPMG's regional survey found that only 49% of African firms obtain external assurance of their ESG disclosures [39]. While TBL and SBL have improved reporting consistency, the absence of independent third-party audits limits the credibility of their reported outcomes. Enhanced external assurance would strengthen accountability and advance SDG 12.6, which calls for improved corporate sustainability reporting. Furthermore, as Gray [28] observes, sustainability is meaningful only when companies can demonstrate outcomes rather than inputs. Both breweries report impressive project outputs—such as liters of water saved or participants trained—but systematic evaluation of long-term community impact (e.g., improved livelihoods, gender empowerment, or ecosystem health) remains limited.

Despite measurable progress in project implementation, the analysis also highlights the need for outcome-based evaluation. While TBL and SBL report extensive activities and participation metrics, longitudinal data on actual social and environmental outcomes—such as livelihood improvements or reduced ecological risk—remain scarce. Establishing long-term monitoring systems would enable a clearer understanding of

sustainable impact, and distinguish between programmatic success and transformative change at the community and ecosystem levels.

Cross-sector collaboration emerges as another decisive factor. Consistent with Austin and Seitanidi [6], who describe transformational partnerships as vehicles for value co-creation, both firms actively engage government, NGOs, and communities to scale impact. TBL's partnerships with WWF, the International Finance Corporation (IFC), and local agricultural bodies, and SBL's alliances with Sightsavers, the Foundation for Disability Hope (FDH), and the National Environment Management Council (NEMC), demonstrate how shared resources and goals can amplify collective outcomes, reinforcing SDG 17 (partnerships for the goals).

Overall, the comparative data underscore different but complementary sustainability emphases. TBL's progress—notably in packaging circularity (89.8%) and water efficiency (2.7 hl/hl)—illustrates tangible environmental gains through operational optimization, while SBL's initiatives, such as the Kwamizi Dam and inclusive agricultural training, embody a socially embedded sustainability model that enhances community resilience and social equity. These trajectories confirm that AB InBev's framework favors environmental performance metrics, whereas Diageo's approach prioritizes inclusive growth and empowerment. Both strategies align with the SDGs, yet demonstrate distinct pathways for operationalizing corporate sustainability within Tanzania's socio-economic context.

In conclusion, the sustainability trajectories of TBL and SBL affirm the evolving role of the private sector as a catalyst for sustainable development in Africa. Their global affiliations provide structure and resources, but it is their contextual innovation, inclusive practices, and cross-sector partnerships that drive genuine impact. As their ESG journeys mature, enhanced transparency, independent verification, and longitudinal impact evaluation will be critical for consolidating progress, and for informing broader academic and policy discourses on corporate sustainability in emerging markets.

9 Conclusion and recommendations

This study examined the sustainability trajectories of TBL and SBL, focusing on their environmental, social, and governance (ESG) strategies and alignment with the SDGs. The comparative analysis revealed that both companies are proactive corporate actors within Tanzania's evolving sustainability landscape. Despite their distinct global affiliations—TBL with AB InBev and SBL with Diageo—each has effectively localized global sustainability frameworks to address national priorities, such as water security, inclusive growth, and environmental protection.

TBL's emphasis on water stewardship, circular packaging, and renewable energy demonstrates how large industrial firms can integrate environmental management into core business operations. Initiatives such as the Ruvu and Msimbazi watershed restoration projects, and the company's achievement of nearly 90% returnable or recycled packaging, reflect tangible progress toward SDGs 6, 12, and 13. SBL, on the other hand, has distinguished itself through community-centered water projects, including the Kwamizi Dam—a TSh 380 million investment supplying 108,800 m³ of clean water to 2,000 people—and its robust inclusion agenda that empowers women and persons with disabilities within agricultural value chains. These outcomes illustrate how corporate sustainability

can simultaneously advance global ESG commitments and address local socio-economic disparities.

The findings affirm the importance of transnational corporate influence in enabling sustainability through shared infrastructure, reporting standards, and investment capital. However, the long-term success of these initiatives depends on contextual adaptation—the ability of firms to tailor global frameworks to local socio-political and environmental realities. Effective sustainability in Tanzania, therefore, requires a hybrid model that balances global alignment with locally responsive innovation.

To consolidate progress, several strategic and policy priorities should guide future action. First, both companies should institutionalize independent verification of their ESG reports through accredited third-party audits to enhance credibility and transparency. Second, they should deepen alignment with international reporting standards, including the Global Reporting Initiative (GRI), the Sustainability Accounting Standards Board (SASB), and the UN Global Compact, to ensure comparability and accountability. Third, expanding stakeholder participation—particularly involving civil society, local communities, and sub-national governments—will improve the legitimacy and social relevance of corporate interventions. Fourth, strengthening supply-chain resilience by integrating smallholder farmers through long-term contracts, training, and digital support systems will advance equitable rural development and contribute to SDG 8. Fifth, promoting inclusive leadership by advancing women and underrepresented groups into managerial and governance roles will embed diversity and social equity within organizational culture. Finally, fostering policy coherence through collaboration with government agencies will align corporate ESG objectives with Tanzania's broader development and climate agendas, amplifying collective impact.

While this study provides important insights into corporate sustainability practices in Tanzania, it is not without limitations—each of which presents opportunities for future research. The analysis relied primarily on secondary data from corporate sustainability reports, which, while comprehensive, may reflect self-reporting bias. Future studies could employ primary data collection, such as stakeholder interviews and community impact assessments, to validate and extend these findings. Moreover, the focus on two breweries limits the sectoral scope; comparative research across multiple industries or countries could illuminate broader regional patterns. Finally, longitudinal studies are needed to assess the enduring social and environmental outcomes of corporate sustainability initiatives over time. Addressing these gaps will deepen our understanding of how multinational firms can meaningfully contribute to inclusive and verifiable sustainable development in emerging economies.

In conclusion, the sustainability pathways of TBL and SBL exemplify the transformative potential of the private sector in advancing national development goals. Their ESG commitments show that profitability and social value creation can be mutually reinforcing when guided by transparent governance, inclusive leadership, and environmental responsibility. As Tanzania's economy continues to evolve, fostering an enabling ecosystem—anchored in collaborative partnerships, independent accountability, and policy coherence—will be essential to sustain long-term impact and achieve equitable, measurable progress toward the SDGs.

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Author contributions

The author (AFM) conceptualized and designed the study, collected and analyzed the data, and wrote all sections of the manuscript.

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Data availability

All data analysed during this study are included in this published article. The study is based exclusively on publicly available secondary sources, including corporate sustainability and ESG reports, which are cited in the reference list. No proprietary or confidential data were used.

Declarations

Ethics approval and consent to participate

Not applicable.

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